



yet they quickly adapted for their own purposes the unfamiliar horses and cattle their invaders brought with them. Finally losing their independence to military force in the mid-19th century, this proud

people still maintain their own strong identity, religion, family structure, and language. The Mapuche call their homeland *Waj Mapu*, meaning “all the Earth,” and their language *Mapudungun*—“the language of the Earth.”



MEN'S WORK

All work outside the home is undertaken by Mapuche men in their role as head of the family. Here, at harvesttime, a hard-working farmer gathers sheaves of ripe wheat from one of the small agricultural plots that surround a collection of *rucas*. As well as wheat, corn, potatoes, beans, vegetable marrows, and peppers are all widely cultivated crops.

YEARLY BLESSINGS

Once a year the Mapuche celebrate their main festival called *Nguillatun*. At this time, they offer thanks for the community's well-being, pray for its continuing safety, and ask the gods to grant abundant harvests and healthy, fertile livestock.



PLAYING TOGETHER

Team activities like this game of *palin* link Mapuche communities and provide a focus for their identity. Similar to field hockey, *palin* involves a curved stick, or *weño*, and a small ball. Matches are played by friendly opponents, or used to settle differences between quarreling parties.



SOCIAL STRUCTURE

Mapuche society is organized into groups of related families, called *lofs*, rather than into towns and villages. Each *lof* consists of 15-20 families under the leadership of a *lonko*, or head man. Here, two generations of Mapuche males set forth in simple woolen garments, which, by tradition, are woven by the women and girls of their *lof*.

The clear, bright blue of the boy's shirt represents sky and spiritual purity to the Mapuche.

